



Cimply — Competitive Brief 2: Horizontal Platforms

Writing sample — Cimply is a demonstration scheduling product for creative studios, built to showcase documentation and product-strategy writing skills. Not a live commercial product.

Competitive data (pricing, features, positioning) reflects research conducted in June 2026 and is illustrative for this writing sample, not current market intelligence. This brief targets a different audience than its companion, “Competitive Brief 1: Scheduling Tools” — sales, handling the objection “why not just use monday/ClickUp/Notion?”, and product, for where the configuration-vs-purpose-built line sits — which shows up in the tone and the Positioning section below.

Why a Separate Brief

Monday.com, ClickUp, and Notion are not scheduling tools. They are horizontal work management platforms — flexible canvases that can be configured to do almost anything, including a version of what Cimply does. They belong in a separate brief because the competitive argument is different:

- **Brief 1 (scheduling tools):** “We do more than a calendar block — our order model gives you brief, communication, status, and time record in one place.”
- **Brief 2 (horizontal platforms):** “You could build this in monday.com — but you’d spend weeks configuring it, your designers would get a generic task board, and you’d still be missing the things that make it actually work.”

The audience for this brief is primarily sales — handling the objection “why not just use [monday/ClickUp/Notion]?” — and product, for understanding where the configuration-vs-purpose-built line sits.

Competitor Overviews

monday.com

Founded: 2012 | Target market: Marketing, operations, and creative teams across company sizes | Pricing note: Raised prices 18% across all tiers in February 2026

Monday.com is a visual work management platform. It is best known for its colorful, flexible boards — essentially spreadsheets with views, automations, and integrations layered on top. It markets aggressively to agencies and creative teams with purpose-built templates for creative requests, content calendars, and campaign management.

Pricing: \$9/user/month (Basic) · \$12/user/month (Standard) · \$19/user/month (Pro) · Enterprise custom

Minimum 3 seats required on all paid plans — effective floor is \$27–57/month.

Recent momentum: AI features added across plans. Significant price increase in early 2026. Pushing into enterprise with compliance and security features.



ClickUp

Founded: 2017 | Target market: Teams of all sizes wanting an all-in-one work platform | Positioning: “One app to replace them all”

ClickUp is the most feature-dense horizontal platform in the market. It combines task management, docs, chat, whiteboards, time tracking, goals, and sprints in a single product. Its free tier is genuinely capable, and its \$7/user/month Unlimited plan undercuts most competitors. It markets heavily to agencies and developer teams.

Pricing: Free · \$7/user/month (Unlimited) · \$12/user/month (Business) · Enterprise custom

Recent momentum: ClickUp Brain (AI) and AI super agents added. Continued aggressive feature expansion. Positioned as the “one tool” for teams tired of managing multiple apps.

Notion

Founded: 2016 | Target market: Knowledge workers, creative teams, startups | Positioning: “The connected workspace”

Notion is a document and database platform that has grown into a lightweight project management tool. Small creative teams use it to centralize briefs, project documentation, and workflow tracking in flexible databases. It excels at knowledge management and documentation — not execution or scheduling.

Pricing: Free (personal) · \$10/user/month (Plus) · \$15/user/month (Business) · Enterprise custom

Recent momentum: Notion AI added. Continued growth among startups and creative teams. Still primarily a docs-and-wiki tool that people stretch into project management.

The Core Difference: Canvas vs. Purpose-Built

The defining characteristic of all three platforms is that they are canvases — they can approximate almost any workflow, but they require configuration to get there. A small studio could build a functional work order system in any of them. The question is what it costs in time, expertise, and ongoing maintenance — and what it still won’t do even after you’ve built it.

Dimension	Cimply	monday.com	ClickUp	Notion
Ready to use on day 1	Yes	Partial	Partial	No
Configuration required	None	Medium	High	High
Estimated setup time	< 1 hour	1–2 days	2–4 weeks	1–3 days
Purpose-built for creative scheduling	Yes	No	No	No
Designer-native experience	Yes	No	No	No
Work order lifecycle (statuses)	Built-in	Configurable	Configurable	Manual
In-order brief and communication	Built-in	Configurable	Configurable	Partial
Time actualization tied to order	Built-in	Add-on/Pro	Built-in	No
Email on assignment	Built-in	Configurable	Yes	Weak
Past-due visual flag	Built-in	Configurable	Yes	No



Feature Comparison

Capability	Cimply (v1)	monday.com	ClickUp	Notion
Work order model				
Work brief on assignment	Strong	Adequate	Adequate	Adequate
Order status lifecycle	Strong	Configurable	Configurable	Weak
In-order messaging / communication	Strong	Weak	Adequate	Adequate
Designer-facing task queue	Strong	Weak	Weak	Weak
Time actualization tied to order	Strong	Pro only	Strong	Absent
Scheduling				
Resource assignment	Strong	Adequate	Adequate	Weak
Availability / capacity view	P1	Adequate	Adequate	Absent
Calendar view	Absent (v1)	Strong	Strong	Adequate
Platform breadth				
Docs / wikis	Absent	Adequate	Strong	Strong
Client collaboration	Absent	Adequate	Weak	Weak
Automations	Absent (v1)	Strong (Pro)	Strong	Weak
Integrations	Absent (v1)	Strong	Strong	Adequate
AI features	Absent (v1)	Adequate	Adequate	Adequate
Usability				
Setup complexity	Low	Medium	High	High
Learning curve	Low	Medium	High	Medium
Mobile experience	Absent (v2)	Adequate	Adequate	Adequate
Pricing				
Entry price/user/month	TBD	\$9 (min 3 seats)	Free–\$7	Free–\$10

Rating scale: Strong / Adequate / Weak / Absent / Configurable (present but requires setup)

Strengths and Weaknesses

monday.com

Strengths: Best visual experience of the three. Strong automations and integrations on Pro. Well-known brand — easy to get budget approved. Good creative request templates. Marketing and agency teams use it comfortably.

Weaknesses: Minimum 3-seat paid requirement makes it expensive for very small studios. Price increased 18% in early 2026 — value perception is eroding. No native file proofing. Performance degrades on large boards. A creative studio would need to configure their own work order workflow from templates — nothing is ready out of the box for the scheduler/designer dynamic. Generic task view for designers.

ClickUp

Strengths: Most capable free tier in the market. \$7/user/month Unlimited plan is genuinely good value. Time tracking is built-in. Can replicate almost any workflow if you invest the time. Huge template library.

Weaknesses: The most common complaint is feature overwhelm — users routinely report a 2–4 week onboarding period before feeling productive. New users often grab multiple conflicting templates and create a messy workspace. The designer experience would be a generic task list



buried in a complex hierarchy of spaces, folders, and lists. ClickUp is a tool for teams with a dedicated ops person to configure and maintain it — not for a 6-person creative studio.

Notion

Strengths: Excellent for briefs, documentation, and knowledge management. Flexible database model can simulate project tracking. Beloved by creative teams for its clean, minimal aesthetic. Free tier is capable.

Weaknesses: Not built for execution or scheduling. Notifications are weak — no reliable alert when a designer is assigned work. No real automation (scored 2.5/5 in independent reviews). No resource management. Status changes are manual with no permission model. A studio running scheduling in Notion is essentially running it in a spreadsheet with better formatting. Time logging does not exist natively.

The Configuration Tax

The most important concept for positioning Cimpily against horizontal platforms is the configuration tax — the hidden cost of building, maintaining, and training on a custom workflow inside a general-purpose tool.

Configuration tax includes:

- **Setup time.** ClickUp realistically requires 2–4 weeks. Monday.com 1–2 days. Notion 1–3 days depending on complexity. Cimpily: under an hour.
- **Maintenance.** Someone has to own the workflow. When the tool updates, automations break. New hires need onboarding into your custom setup, not just the tool.
- **Drift.** Without enforcement, teams stop using the configured workflow and revert to ad hoc behavior. The Slack thread comes back. The custom status no one maintains stops being updated.
- **The gaps that remain.** Even after configuration, horizontal tools still won't give a designer a purpose-built queue showing their orders, brief, and communication in one place. That experience requires more configuration than most studios will invest in.

The configuration tax is invisible to a studio that hasn't done it yet. It becomes very visible 6 weeks in.

Positioning — How Cimpily Wins This Argument

The objection: “*We already use monday.com / ClickUp / Notion — why do we need another tool?*”

The response is not “we have more features.” It's three things:

1. **You'd have to build it.** Monday.com doesn't have a scheduler/designer workflow out of the box. You'd configure it from templates, spend days getting it right, and still end up with a generic task board your designers don't actually want to open.
2. **Your designers' experience would still be generic.** In any horizontal tool, the designer sees a task in a list. In Cimpily, they see their queue, the full brief, the conversation, and



exactly what they need to do. That's the thing that drives adoption on the resource side — which is the hard half of the problem.

3. **Ready on day one.** A small studio can create their first order, assign it to a designer, and have that designer respond — in under an hour. No templates, no configuration, no training. That's the pitch.

Opportunities

- **The “good enough” trap works in Cimply’s favor.** Studios using monday.com or ClickUp for scheduling have usually done a mediocre job of it — the workflow was set up by whoever had time, it's not quite right, and nobody loves it. Cimply's pitch to these studios is “better for this specific thing” not “replace your entire tool.”
- **Notion users are the most likely switchers.** Notion for scheduling is the biggest stretch — it's actively fighting the tool. These studios know it's not working but haven't found a better option. Cimply is a natural landing spot.
- **Cimply and monday.com are not mutually exclusive.** A studio might use monday.com for client project management and Cimply for internal resource scheduling. Positioning Cimply as a complement rather than a replacement lowers the switching barrier and is often more honest.

Threats

- **ClickUp’s free tier is genuinely hard to argue against for cost-sensitive studios.** A designer and a scheduler can use ClickUp for free, build a passable workflow, and never pay. The counter is configuration tax and experience quality — but “free” is a powerful objection to overcome.
- **Monday.com’s brand recognition creates inertia.** It's the tool leadership has heard of. Budget requests for monday.com sail through; budget requests for Cimply require explanation. This is a sales and marketing problem as much as a product problem.
- **AI features are widening the gap on platform breadth.** All three platforms are adding AI features Cimply won't have at launch — AI task generation, automated summaries, smart scheduling suggestions. These won't matter to a studio that just needs to assign work clearly, but they will matter in demos against buyers who equate AI features with innovation.

Strategic Implications for Cimply

1. **Lead with “ready on day one” against horizontal platforms.** The setup time comparison is the most visceral argument. “You could spend two weeks configuring ClickUp or be up and running in Cimply in an hour” is a demo-able claim.
2. **Show the designer screen.** The moment that wins against horizontal tools is showing what the designer sees. A purpose-built queue with a brief, a conversation thread, and a clear status — vs. a task buried in a ClickUp hierarchy. No horizontal tool can match this without significant configuration.



3. **Position as complementary where possible.** “Cimply for scheduling, monday.com for client projects” is a lower-friction entry than asking a studio to rip out a tool they already have. Get in the door first; displacement comes later.
4. **Target the Notion scheduling user first.** They already know their current setup is a stretch. They’re actively looking for something better. Cimply is the obvious answer.
5. **Do not compete on breadth.** Automations, AI, integrations, docs — horizontal platforms will always win on feature count. Compete on fit: Cimply is the right tool for this specific job, and the right tool beats the most powerful tool when setup time and adoption matter.

What to Monitor

Signal	Why it matters	How often
monday.com pricing changes	Already raised 18% in 2026 — further increases help Cimply’s value case	Quarterly
ClickUp free tier changes	If they restrict the free tier, cost-sensitive studios need alternatives	Quarterly
monday.com or ClickUp agency-specific templates	Signals investment in the creative scheduling use case	Monthly
Notion database / automation updates	If Notion adds real automation and notifications, it becomes a stronger substitute	Monthly
Review site mentions of “scheduling” + “monday/ClickUp/Notion”	Reveals pain points Cimply’s positioning can target	Monthly

Research conducted June 15, 2026. Pricing and feature details change frequently — verify before use in sales or investor materials.

Sources

monday.com: [ProofHub](#), [Automation Atlas](#), [Capterra](#), [Workamajig](#)

ClickUp: [TeamHub](#), [Tech.co](#), [Capterra](#)

Notion: [ClickUp Learn](#), [eesel AI](#), [Capterra](#), [Notionry](#)

Category context: [Storyflow](#)